

Trucks

Trucks are used for carrying cargo along roads. Their journeys can range from a few kilometres on local deliveries to thousands of kilometres across continents. The first trucks were built in the 1890s, and were driven by steam engines. Since then, trucks have grown ever larger. In Australia, trucks called road trains tow hundreds of tonnes of cargo across long distances in several full-sized trailers. Some trucks are "rigid", that is, built in one piece. Articulated lorries are built in two sections: a tractor unit and a semi-trailer, which is designed to carry specialized loads. Great skill is required to drive an articulated lorry.

Inside a truck cab

Long-distance truck drivers spend many hours in the cabs of their trucks. Cabs are designed for comfort, and some of the controls, such as the steering and brakes, are power-assisted to make them easy to use. Many cabs have a small rear room, with a bunk, washing facilities, and television. To help prevent accidents, some countries have introduced tachometers to record how many hours the truck is on the road. It is illegal for the driver to go beyond a certain number of hours.

Heating controls (temperature selector and fan speed selector) keep cab at a comfortable temperature in hot or cold weather.

Cassette, radio, and CB (citizens' band) radio provide entertainment on the road. Drivers may use CB to warn each other of traffic jams.



Adjustable nozzles allow fresh air into the cab.

Warning indicators light up if anything goes wrong with the truck.

Gauges, such as the speedometer, show speed, engine temperature, and the amount of fuel left.

Large diameter steering wheel is easy to turn with power assistance. This is known as power steering.

Gear selector

Clutch pedal controls gears.

Brake pedal

Accelerator pedal

Karl Benz

In 1886, German engineer Karl Benz (1844–1929) patented his first car, using an internal combustion engine. The car had electric ignition, three wheels, differential gears, and was water-cooled. In 1926, his company merged with Daimler to become one of the leading car and truck producers in the world.



Research and development

Modern research aims at improving car economy, safety, and ecology. Because petroleum reserves are limited and its use is environmentally unsound, research is taking place into new fuels from sustainable sources, such as plant oils. Researchers are also experimenting with new materials for car parts, including plastics for car bodies. Car manufacturers are aware that making cars cleaner and safer is likely to improve sales.



A catalytic converter from a car exhaust

Catalytic converter

Cars and trucks are gradually becoming "cleaner", which means they create less pollution. Most new cars have a catalytic converter, which removes carbon monoxide, nitrogen oxides, and other poisonous chemicals from the exhaust gases.



Crash test dummy

Testing airbag inflation

Safety features

Manufacturers are constantly developing new safety features, such as airbags that inflate automatically in the event of an accident. They are also working on new ways of preventing accidents, such as anti-lock brakes.

Types of truck

Most trucks start life as a standard chassis and cab. Car manufacturers can then add the body, which determines the function of the truck. Common specialized trucks include rubbish trucks, flat trailers to transport large items, such as cars, tankers, fire engines, and vehicles modified to carry animals, such as horse boxes.



Rubbish truck

This truck has a closed container for rubbish and a rubbish-bin lift that empties a bin into the body through a protective shield.



Car transporter

A car transporter is used to convey cars to showrooms. There are ramps at the back which fold down at the rear so that the cars can be driven on and off. The trailer of a car transporter can carry up to 18 vehicles.

Storage space above the cab



Horse box

This truck carries horses to shows. The horse enters the truck via a door at the rear, which folds down to make a loading ramp.

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